

~ in honour of the lady with no name in the game ~

Nyonya Mei

林梅蘭

LIM MEI LAN · 1908 – 1996

She was not born a Tan. She married no Tan. No grandchild carried her name. But for **fifty-one years** she stood at the back kitchen of the house on Lebu­h Aceh, stirring santan, folding pandan, layering kuih nine times over — while the family upstairs ate, and laughed, and forgot her name.

Today we remember.
These are her five recipes.

★ TAN FAMILY · 9 MAY 2026 · 陳家根譜 ★

~ R E C I P E 1 O F 5 ~

Kuih Talam

兩層糕 · the two-layer cake
green pandan below · white coconut above

Two layers, never one. The green is the earth, the white is the rain.

serves 9 time 1h+ level easy

Ingredients

Bottom · pandan

- 120 g *rice flour*
- 30 g *tapioca flour*
- 30 g *hoen kwe*
- 180 g *gula melaka*
- 250 ml *pandan juice*
- 250 ml water · pinch salt

Top · coconut

- 50 g rice flour · 20 g tapioca
- 10 g hoen kwe
- 250 ml thick *santan*
- 100 ml water · ½ tsp salt

Method

- Bottom:** melt gula melaka in water, strain. Mix with pandan juice. Whisk in flours + salt. Cook on low ~5 min until thick.
- Steam:** pour into greased 8" pan. Steam 20 min on medium.
- Top:** whisk all top ingredients. Cook on low ~3 min until thick.
- Layer & steam:** pour gently over green. Steam 15 min more.
- Cool 2 h.** Cut into 9 squares with a wet knife.

Mei's note

Cut clean, or don't cut at all. A messy talam tells the cook was angry.

NYONYA MEI 1

~ R E C I P E 2 O F 5 ~

Kuih Kaya

椰漿蛋糕 · coconut egg jam cake
pandan custard above · glutinous rice below

Towkay's first wife asked me for this every Sunday for thirty-one years. That is also love.

serves 12 time 1½h level easy

Ingredients

Glutinous base

- 300 g *glutinous rice*, soaked 4 h
- 200 ml thin santan
- ½ tsp salt · 2 pandan leaves
- 1 tbsp blue pea water (*optional*)

Pandan custard

- 5 large *eggs*
- 200 g caster sugar
- 250 ml thick santan
- 120 ml pandan juice
- 40 g rice flour · 20 g plain
- ¼ tsp salt

Method

- Base:** drain rice. Mix with santan, salt, pandan. Steam in 8" pan 25 min. Press flat.
- Custard:** whisk eggs + sugar pale. Add santan + pandan juice. Sift flours. *Strain twice.*
- Layer:** pour gently over rice base.
- Slow steam** on lowest heat 40 min, lid wrapped in cloth (no drips).
- Cool 2 h.** Slice with wet knife.

Mei's note

Strain the kaya twice or your guests will know. They will not say it. But they will know.

NYONYA MEI 2

~ R E C I P E 3 O F 5 ~

Kuih Lapis

九層糕 · the nine-layer cake
pink · white · nine times over

Nine layers, like the peony on my apron. The trick is not the colour — it is the waiting.

serves 12 time 1¾h level slow

Ingredients

Single batter

- 250 g *rice flour*
- 100 g tapioca · 50 g hoen kwe
- 250 g caster sugar
- 500 ml thick santan
- 500 ml water · 1 tsp salt
- 2 pandan leaves, knotted

To divide

- Half: 4–5 drops *red colour*
- Half: leave plain (white)

Pour 9 layers total: P-W-P-W-P-W-P-W-P

Method

- Syrup:** heat santan + water + sugar + salt + pandan until dissolved. Cool fully.
- Batter:** whisk in all flours. Strain. Divide. Colour one half pink.
- Heat pan:** grease 8" pan, steam empty 5 min on high.
- Layer by layer:** 1 ladle pink, steam 5 min. 1 ladle white, steam 5 min. Repeat — 9 layers, ~45 min total.
- Final 10 min** steam. Cool 2 h. Cut strips. Eat with fingers.

Mei's note

If layers blur, steam too low. If they crack, too high. Find the middle. Like the middle sister.

NYONYA MEI 3

~ R E C I P E 4 O F 5 ~

Kuih Dadar

椰絲卷餅 · ketayap
pandan crepe rolled around gula melaka coconut

Ah Cai took two with him in a banana leaf in 1942. He never came back. I still make six every Sunday.

serves 10 time 45m level easy

Ingredients

Pandan crepe

- 120 g plain flour · 1 tbsp tapioca
- 1 large *egg*
- 180 ml pandan juice
- 120 ml thin santan
- ¼ tsp salt · 1 tsp oil

Inti · filling

- 200 g grated *coconut*
- 120 g gula melaka, fine
- 50 ml water
- 2 pandan leaves · pinch salt

Method

- Inti first:** melt gula melaka with water + pandan, strain. Toss with coconut + salt on low heat 5 min — sticky, not dry. Cool.
- Batter:** whisk egg + pandan + santan. Add salt + oil. Sift flours. Strain. Rest 15 min.
- Crepe:** small oiled non-stick pan. 2 tbsp batter, swirl thin. Cook 30 sec — matte top. Slide off. *Don't flip.*
- Roll:** 1 tbsp inti at one edge. Fold sides, roll like spring roll.
- Serve warm or room temp.

Mei's note

Don't flip. One side cooked is enough. The other should remember it was once batter.

NYONYA MEI 4

~ R E C I P E 5 O F 5 ~

Kuih Bingka Ubi

木薯糕 · baked tapioca cake
deep golden top · soft chewy middle

Towkay's daughter said it tasted like the sun. I told her the sun was free, and so was this. I lied.

serves 12 time 1¼h level easy

Ingredients

Cake

- 500 g grated *tapioca*, drained
- 200 g caster sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 250 ml thick santan
- 50 g melted butter
- ½ tsp salt · 1 tsp vanilla
- 1 tbsp tapioca flour (*if wet*)

Glaze

- 2 tbsp santan
- 1 tsp sugar · pinch salt

Method

- Heat oven** 175 °C. Grease 8" pan.
- Drain well:** squeeze tapioca thoroughly. Watery tapioca = sad bingka.
- Mix:** whisk eggs + sugar + salt pale. Add santan, butter, vanilla. Fold in tapioca + flour.
- Bake 30 min** — top should just be setting.
- Glaze & finish:** brush with glaze. Bake 20–25 min more until deep golden + glossy.
- Cool 1 h** before cutting.

Mei's note

If the top is pale, you took it out too early. A bingka with no colour is a bingka with no story.

NYONYA MEI 5